

HS4002: Lecture 4A

Writing Survey Questions

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Administrative matters

Prep. before class facilitation exercises

Ahead of the week of your group's presentation, please email me by Sunday midnight a brief outline of what you're going to cover or do. This is so that I can better coordinate what I do with what you do or don't do.

Scoping Memo due tonight, 10pm.

Thinking about Underlying Concepts

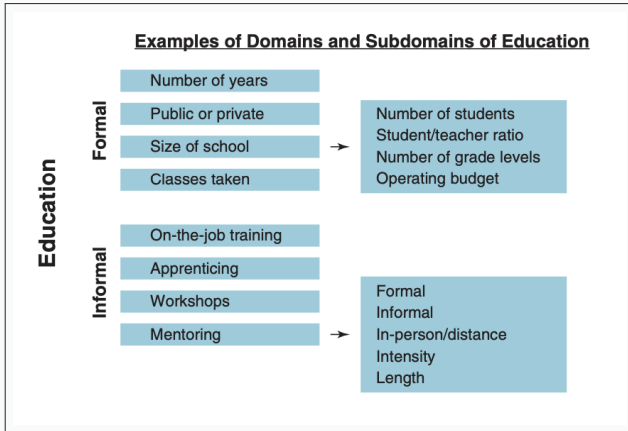
“To discover quantitative regularity, one must know what regularity one is seeking, and one’s instruments must be designed accordingly.” – Thomas Kuhn (1961:190).

Questions and Concepts

- Clearly define the goals of the survey (i.e., the research question) and identify the concepts of interest.
- In normal positivist science, concepts precede measures.
 - The better we understand our concepts, the better designed our questions will be.
- Our survey questions turn invisible concepts visible.

Example of Education

Figure 1: Measuring education in surveys



- Precedence matters.
- Always check how previous studies or surveys have posed similar questions.
 - e.g. if you're asking for someone's race and ethnicity, check out a similar study have asked these questions.
- Follow conventions, within reason.
 - They tend to be well-validated.
 - It makes results commensurable.

Types of Questions

Easy and Hard Questions

Some questions are easy to answer:

- Demographic questions
- Simple recall questions
- Salient attitudes and opinions

What year were you born?

Year born

How old are you?

Age

Others may be "hard" to answer:

- Complex recall
- Complex attitudes/opinions

In your opinion, how effective do you think citizens' groups are in helping to solve environmental problems?

- ☐ Very effective
- ☐ Somewhat effective
- ☐ A little effective
- ☐ Not at all effective

Close-ended Questions

- Close-ended responses:
 - We provide answer choices limit the available possibilities from which respondents can choose.
 - Can use nominal or ordinal categories.

Closed-ended ordinal question

Question stem **Overall, how satisfied are you with living in Nebraska?**

Answer choices

- ☐ Completely satisfied
- ☐ Very satisfied
- ☐ Somewhat satisfied
- ☐ Not too satisfied
- ☐ Not at all satisfied

Open-ended Questions

- Open-ended responses:
 - Allows respondents to freely answer the question as they want.
 - More effortful for both respondent and researcher.

Open-ended questions

Question stem **What is the most important problem facing Nebraska today?**

Answer space

Partially-closed Questions

- Partially-closed (hybrid) response:
 - Hybrid approaches that include an "Other" category where respondents can provide free responses.

Partially closed-ended question

Question stem **What are your favorite women's sports at the University of Nebraska?**

Answer choices

- ☐ Basketball
- ☐ Cross Country
- ☐ Gymnastics
- ☐ Soccer
- ☐ Softball
- ☐ Swimming and Diving
- ☐ Tennis
- ☐ Volleyball
- ☐ Other: Please specify

How Survey Modes Matter

Survey Modes Can Introduce Bias

- Interviewer effects
- Aural vs visual mediums of communication.

Interviewer Effects

- Social desirability bias.
 - The tendency to provide answers that put one in a good light with the person who asks the question.
- Acquiescence effects
 - The tendency to agree with someone rather than disagree.
- Interview bias
 - Fixed interviewer characteristics affect how respondents answer questions, e.g. race or gender.
- Interview variance
 - Variation in how interviewers administer a question.

Aural vs Visual Communications

- The responses order of questions can introduce bias.
- Primacy effects:
 - The tendency to more frequently choose from among the first categories offered regardless of their content.
 - More common in visual mediums.
- Recency effects:
 - The tendency to more frequently choose from among the last categories offered regardless of their content.
 - More common in aural mediums.

Class Exercise

Part 1: Design Survey Questions

In small-groups, design a four-question online survey that seeks to measure a person's taste for popular music, as you understand it.

Please include one open-ended questions, and three close-ended questions in this survey.

Write down this survey questionnaire on a piece of paper.

Part 2: Evaluate Survey Questions

Exchange the survey questions you've designed with a different group.

Compare and evaluate the surveys questions completed by the other groups.

To what extent do they measure taste? To what extent might they be "biased"?

Practical Guidelines

Some Practical Guidelines

1. Make sure questions are relevant to a respondent.
2. Make sure the question is technically correct to the target population.
3. Use simple and familiar words.
4. Be as concise as possible.
5. Use simple sentence structures.
6. Use actual questions rather than imperative sentences.
7. Avoid double negatives.
8. Choose appropriate question ordering.

Thanks for listening :)